One Neighbor's Petition Helped Stop a $5 Billion Data Center

From: NPR World Mined: 2026-11-07 5 min read

In Landover, Maryland, nearly 90 acres of empty land stretch out where a shopping mall once stood. Landover Mall closed in 2002, and the site has sat mostly vacant ever since. In 2024, the developer that built the mall won approval to build a $5 billion **data center** campus there.

A **data center** is a giant building full of computers that keep the internet running. **Data centers** use huge amounts of water and electricity, and many run backup generators that burn diesel fuel. Taylor Frazier McCollum lived less than a mile from the site, and she did not want one in her neighborhood. 'Why would you want to bring water-polluting, diesel-generating **data centers** right down the street from where people live, work, play?' she asked.

McCollum started a **petition** that gathered more than 25,000 signatures. The **petition** led to large protests and several local pauses, called **moratoriums**, on **data center** projects across the county. The $5 billion project, which was set to break ground between 2026 and 2027, is now blocked. Across the country, community opposition has prompted about 500 such **moratoriums** on **data centers**.

The fight changed McCollum's life. She does not own a home. In 2024, she and her young daughter were **evicted** from their apartment after her wages were cut, and they moved in with her grandfather. She went to county meetings, testified before Maryland lawmakers, and found herself working alongside **environmentalists**, neighbors worried about electric bills, and people new to organizing.

Not everyone agrees the pause is good news. The county faces a budget **deficit**, and some worry about lost tax money. Council member Wanika Fisher said the county needs development and a real conversation about its economic future. McCollum now wants a full ban on **data center** projects and has shared her story with communities in Atlanta, Memphis, and Zambia. She hopes to run for office one day, after she pays off her debts and finds a home.

Word Treasure

data center -- A giant building full of computers that keep the internet running.
petition -- A written request signed by many people, asking leaders to change something.
moratoriums -- Temporary pauses on an activity, decided by a government.
evicted -- Forced to leave a home, usually because rent could not be paid.
deficit -- When a government spends more money than it takes in.
environmentalists -- People who work to protect nature and the environment.

Background you need

A data center is a large building full of computers that store information and keep websites and online services running, and running all those computers takes a great deal of water and electricity.

In Landover, Maryland, a developer wanted to build a large data center campus on land where a shopping mall once stood and had sat mostly empty since the mall closed.

A neighbor, Taylor Frazier McCollum, worried about pollution and the strain on water and power near homes, so she started a petition and joined protests that led local officials to pause data center projects, called moratoriums, while the community debated what should happen next.

Break it down

LEAD: A neighbor's petition helped block a large data center campus planned for empty mall land in Landover, Maryland.

KEY EVENT: McCollum started a petition that gathered more than 25,000 signatures.

+- WHO: Taylor Frazier McCollum, a neighbor living less than a mile from the site

+- WHAT: A $5 billion data center campus planned where Landover Mall once stood

+- WHERE: Landover, Maryland, on nearly 90 acres of mostly vacant land

+- WHEN: The developer won approval in 2024, and the project was set to break ground between 2026 and 2027

EVIDENCE: The petition led to large protests and several local pauses on data center projects, and community opposition has prompted about 500 such pauses across the country.

OPEN QUESTION: Whether the county will choose a full ban, as McCollum wants, or pursue development to address its budget deficit, as Wanika Fisher argues it must discuss.

Why it matters

This story shows how one neighbor can shape what gets built near homes, and it raises a wider question about balancing clean water, air, and power bills against jobs and tax money from new development.

Test what you remember

1. What stood on the Landover site before it sat mostly vacant?

- (A) A data center campus
- (B) A power plant
- (C) An apartment building
- (D) A shopping mall

2. Why did Taylor Frazier McCollum oppose the data center plan?

- (A) She worried it would pollute water and burn diesel fuel near where people live, work, and play
- (B) She thought the site was too far from her home
- (C) She wanted the developer to build apartments instead
- (D) She wanted the old mall to reopen as a shopping center

3. How many signatures did McCollum's petition gather?

- (A) Fewer than 90
- (B) Exactly 5,000
- (C) About 500
- (D) More than 25,000

4. What did the petition lead to in the county?

- (A) The mall reopening the same year
- (B) A ban on all new buildings in Maryland
- (C) The developer moving the project to another state
- (D) Large protests and several local pauses, called moratoriums, on data center projects

5. What happened to McCollum and her young daughter in 2024?

- (A) They were hired by the developer to run the data center
- (B) They moved in with her grandfather after they were evicted from their apartment when her wages were cut
- (C) They moved to Atlanta to start a new petition
- (D) They bought a home near the mall site

6. What did Council member Wanika Fisher say the county needs?

- (A) A full ban on data center projects
- (B) No new development of any kind
- (C) Development and a real conversation about its economic future
- (D) The project to break ground at once

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: D 4: D 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Taylor Frazier McCollum and neighbors who opposed the project: They worried about water pollution, diesel generators, and electric bills from a data center close to homes, and McCollum now wants a full ban on data center projects.

2. People worried about the county budget: They worry the pause means lost tax money while the county faces a budget deficit.

3. Council member Wanika Fisher: She said the county needs development and a real conversation about its economic future.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):